

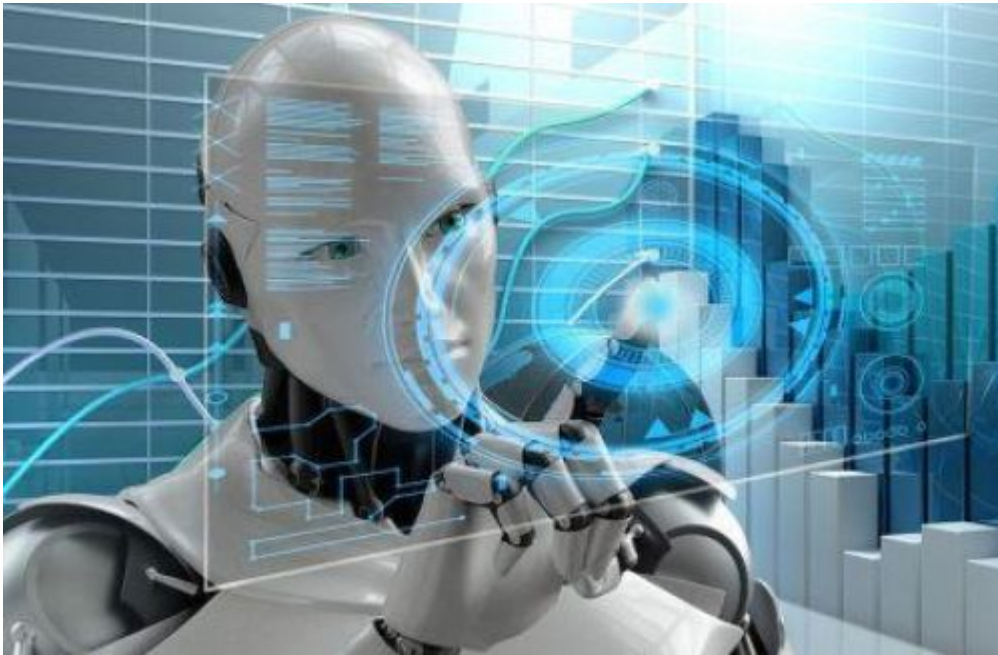


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News

South Africa Tops African Generative AI Adoption Rankings in 2026 Microsoft Report



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- **South Africa ranked as Africa's leading user of generative AI tools in the first quarter of 2026, with a 23.1% adoption rate among people aged 15-64.**
- **Microsoft reported widening disparities between developed and developing countries, with average GenAI adoption rates of 27.5% and 15.4% respectively.**
- **The United Arab Emirates remained the global leader in generative AI usage, with 70.1% of its population using GenAI tools.**

South Africa, Namibia, and both Libya and Gabon ranked as Africa's top users of generative artificial intelligence tools such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude and Copilot during the first quarter of 2026, according to a report that Microsoft published on May 7, 2026.

Titled "*Global AI Diffusion - Q1 2026 Trends and Insights*," the report measured global AI diffusion based on the proportion of people aged 15 to 64 who used a generative AI solution between January 1 and March 31, 2026. Microsoft based the study on aggregated and anonymized telemetry data. The company then adjusted the data to account for differences in operating system and connected device market shares, internet penetration rates and national populations.

South Africa ranked among the countries where generative AI adoption has become relatively established. Some 23.1% of the country's population aged 15 to

64 used the technology during the first quarter of 2026, compared with 19.3% during the same period a year earlier.

Wide Disparities

With a usage rate of 15.1% during the first three months of 2026, Namibia ranked second in Africa, ahead of both Libya and Gabon at 15%, followed by Egypt and Botswana at 14.8%, Senegal at 13.9%, Tunisia at 13.5% and Algeria at 13.2%.

Zambia and Ivory Coast shared 10th place on the continent, with 13.1% of their populations using generative AI solutions.

(See the full ranking of the 46 African countries surveyed below.)

Globally, the use of generative AI tools increased to an average of 17.8% of the population aged 15-64 during the first quarter of 2026, compared with 15.1% during the same period in 2025.

The United Arab Emirates retained its position as the global leader in generative AI adoption, with 70.1% of its population using the technology. The Gulf monarchy ranked ahead of Singapore at 63.4%, Norway at 48.6%, Ireland at 48.4% and France at 47.8%.

Moreover, the report highlighted widening disparities between developed and developing countries. Developed countries recorded an average generative AI usage rate of 27.5% during the first quarter of 2026, representing growth of 2.8 percentage points compared with the second half of 2025.

In contrast, developing countries posted an average usage rate of 15.4% during the first three months of 2026. That figure represented an increase of only 1.3 percentage points compared with the second half of the previous year.

The report said the widening gap reflected systemic challenges across developing economies, where limited access to reliable electricity, internet connectivity and digital skills continued to slow generative AI adoption.

"Until these fundamental gaps are addressed, the benefits of this technology will remain unevenly distributed, risking the further aggravation of existing global economic inequalities," the report stated.

Walid Kéfi

Ranking of African Countries With the Highest Generative AI Usage in Q1 2026

1-South Africa (23.1% of the population)

2-Namibia (15.1%)

3-Libya (15%)

- Gabon (15%)

5-Egypt (14.8%)

- Botswana (14.8%)

7-Senegal (13.9%)

8-Tunisia (13.5%)

9-Algeria (13.2%)

10-Zambia (13.1%)

- Ivory Coast (13.1%)

12-Morocco (11.7%)

13-Gambia (11.4%)

14-Angola (10.9%)

- Madagascar (10.9%)
- Malawi (10.9%)
- Mozambique (10.9%)

18-Benin (10.1%)

- Burkina Faso (10.1%)
- Ghana (10.1%)
- Guinea (10.1%)

- Guinea-Bissau (10.1%)
- Liberia (10.1%)
- Mali (10.1%)
- Mauritania (10.1%)
- Niger (10.1%)
- Nigeria (10.1%)
- Sierra Leone (10.1%)
- Togo (10.1%)

30-Lesotho (9.8%)

31-Kenya (8.7%)

- Cameroon (8.7%)
- Central African Republic (8.7%)
- Chad (8.7%)
- Congo (8.7%)
- DR Congo (8.7%)

37-Zimbabwe (8.5%)

38-Burundi (7.6%)

- Eritrea (7.6%)
- Ethiopia (7.6%)
- Somalia (7.6%)
- South Sudan (7.6%)
- Sudan (7.6%)
- Tanzania (7.6%)
- Uganda (7.6%)

46-Rwanda (7.2%)

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